

The Fundamental Rules of Caucusing

This description of rules governing ISEF caucus decisions assumes an understanding of the process that caucuses will follow in determining awards. Before reading further, please review document A. *How the Caucus Will Decide Awards* in Section V of the *Judge Information Board*.

In order that all award decisions fairly represent the consensus of judges in each category, ISEF caucuses will follow a formal process to gauge that consensus. This process involves a specific set of decisions following two fundamental rules.

Caucus Decisions

Summarizing V.A. *How the Caucus Will Decide Awards*, and assuming no errors, there are only four different decisions that judges will need to make during award deliberations:

During Phase I: Growing the Pool

- Whether to add a specific project to the Pool, and
- Whether to close the Pool to further additions.

During Phase II: Selecting the Awardees

- Whether to promote a specific project to the Awarded Table, and
- Whether to demote a specific project to the Rejected Table.

Rule #1 – Caucus Decisions Must Be Deliberate

The first rule requires that anything the caucus decides must be decided by the caucus.

Fundamental Rule #1

No action affecting any project may be taken by the caucus unless approved by a majority of the judges voting.

All decisions put to a vote must be of the form to approve or disapprove some action. In other words, all votes will ask for a simple “yes” or “no” vote. Approval requires a majority vote.

Fundamental Rule #1 Simplified

All actions require caucus-wide approval.

Co-chairs cannot on their own make any of the decisions listed in the *Caucus Decisions* section above. Nor can they act on any project solely on the suggestion of some judges that they find reasonable, even if they *think* that the majority of caucus members would approve. All actions require a majority vote by the caucus to be effected.

The phrase “majority of the judges voting” means that only “yes” and “no” votes are counted. Abstentions are ignored. A consensus of the caucus requires that there be more “yes” votes than “no” votes. Otherwise, the proposed action cannot be taken.

Co-chairs will remain impartial during the caucus discussion. In order to preserve their impartiality, co-chairs at ISEF do not vote on any action. Co-chairs are in charge of the caucus and will decide when to call for a vote on each issue, but they will not vote.

Rule #2 – Caucus Decisions Must Be Taken Seriously

The second rule requires the caucus to respect its own decisions.

Fundamental Rule #2

No caucus decision approved by a majority of judges may be reversed except by a subsequent majority vote.

Put more directly:

Fundamental Rule #2 Simplified

Don't go backwards.

There are two practical reasons for respecting this rule. First, undoing earlier decisions without significant cause (here, a majority vote) wastes everyone's time. Second, if judges cannot rely on decisions that they have already voted on to settle the issue, they have little incentive to pay attention to subsequent votes.

This rule has different consequences for each of the four decisions in the *Caucus Decisions* section above, which we now enumerate.

Phase I: Whether to Add a Specific Project to the Pool of Award Candidates

During Phase I, project merits are discussed *briefly* to determine whether there is reason to expect that the project at issue is likely to be award-worthy and that it deserves to be discussed more fully in Phase II. In order that the Pool not become too large to be helpful, it is important that the projects which are discussed are considered sufficiently thoroughly so that the caucus can meaningfully distinguish between projects that are and are not worthy of fuller discussion.

Consequently,

- Projects receiving a majority vote in favor of being added to the Pool will be added to the Pool and not discussed further until Phase II.
- Projects *failing* to receive a majority vote are not only *not* added to the Pool, but also *cannot again be proposed for addition to the same award Pool*. Such projects may be added subsequently to any lower-level Pool, but not to the current Pool.

Judges must be aware of this consequence of a negative vote: a majority vote against the project must be taken as seriously as a majority vote in favor. This is why judges proposing a project for addition to the Pool must make a strong case up front. If they do not, then the necessarily brief discussion of project merits may be so brief that a majority of the caucus will not support the proffered contender being added to the limited Pool. There are no second tries at being added to the Pool for any given award level.

Phase I: Whether to Close the Pool to Further Additions

The prohibition against going backwards on this decision is obvious. Once a majority of the caucus has decided that the Pool of Award Candidates is large enough (that is, the majority has decided that the Pool contains all of the projects with a likely chance of being selected for the *current award level*) then the caucus will move to Phase II.

Importantly, the caucus will then *not* return later to Phase I to grow the Pool even further because the caucus has already voted against that action.

Of course, this means that the question of closing the Pool cannot be called for a vote until the size of the Pool has reached at least the number of awards to be given at the current award level. Generally speaking, Pools should be larger than the number of awards, but the “right” size for any award level cannot be determined in advance because it depends upon the specific circumstances presented to each caucus at each award level.

Phase II: Whether to Promote a Specific Project to the Awarded Table

Phase II: Whether to Demote a Specific Project to the Rejected Table

Here we consider these two questions together because the exact same considerations apply to moving any project out of the Pool in either direction.

These two questions should only be asked after all projects in the Pool have been discussed sufficiently thoroughly that all judges will have had an opportunity to informally decide on their own preferred ranking of the candidate projects. Since there may be many candidates in play during this vote, the consequences of a vote to move a project out of the Pool to either the Awarded or Rejected Table are different from the corresponding question during Phase I.

- Projects receiving a majority vote in favor of being moved out of the Pool to either the Awarded or Rejected Table will be moved to that table.
- Projects *failing* to receive a majority vote will not be moved, but remain eligible to be moved to either table by a future vote.

Projects promoted to the Awarded Table have been selected for the current award and should not be the subject of any further discussion by the caucus. Projects demoted to the Rejected table have been determined by a majority vote not to be eligible for the current award level and should not be the subject of any further discussion until the caucus considers the next lower-level award. Because these are decisions made by a majority of the caucus, these decisions should not be revisited. Consequently, no project in the Awarded Table should ever be returned to the Pool (absent a majority vote reversing that decision), just as no project in the Rejected Table should be returned to the Pool (absent a similar majority vote).

In contrast, projects *not* receiving majority support for Phase II moves retain the same status that they had prior to the vote. It is quite common for projects *not* to receive majority support for a Phase II move. When the number of projects in the Pool is greater than two, majority support for promoting *any* project may not be possible, so a “no” vote cannot be taken to mean anything more than that no consensus has formed.

When determining whether a project is to be promoted or demoted from the Pool, a “no” vote simply leaves the project in place, eligible to be voted into either of the other tables at a later time.

Exception to Fundamental Rule #2

Rule #2 against going backwards does not mean that the caucus cannot revisit earlier decisions if given sufficient cause. For example, if immediately after a vote, a number of judges complain that they misunderstood what the vote was for, then after clarification of the question, *but no further discussion of project merits*, the vote should be retaken. This example illustrates the reason why all votes must be yes/no decisions whose consequence must be clear to all judges.

As with any caucus action, going backwards is an action that requires a majority vote of the caucus. If a majority of the caucus votes to revisit an earlier decision, then it should do so because the caucus will then have acknowledged its earlier mistake.

This rule against going backwards applies only to decisions of the caucus and does not forbid correcting obvious mistakes that do not reflect decisions of the caucus. For example, if the caucus votes to select project A for an award and a co-chair erroneously promotes project B to the Awarded Table (which moves are always done in plain sight of the entire caucus), then this simple mistake should be pointed out and corrected immediately, and does not require any vote by the caucus.

Points of Emphasis

1. All decisions of the caucus require a majority of those voting and should be presented as simple yes/no questions.
2. All decisions should be taken seriously, and once taken, should never be reversed except by a subsequent contravening majority vote.